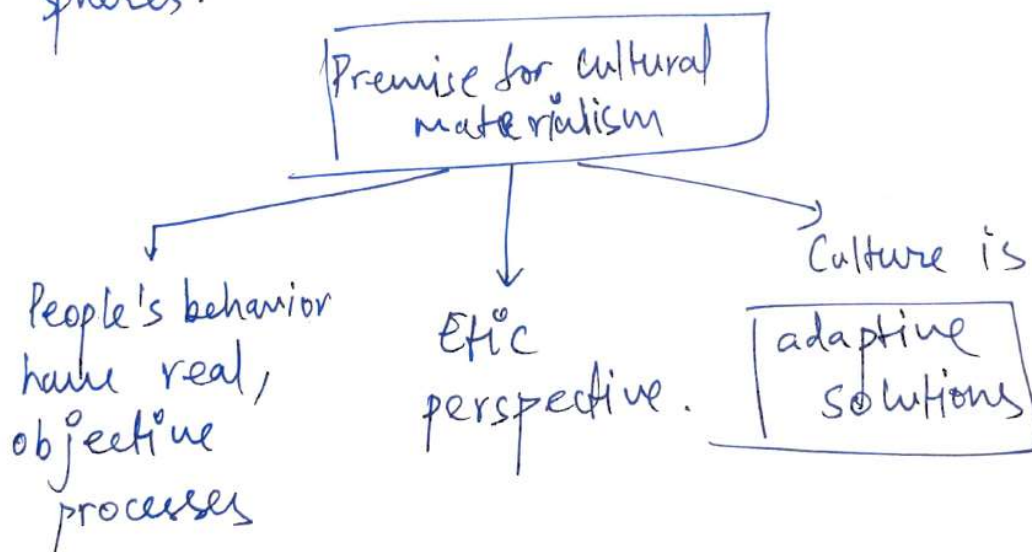


7.c) Explain Cultural materialism school of thought in Anthropology. (15 marks)

Marvin Harris in his work "Cultural Materialism: A struggle for science of culture" brought out the cultural materialism theory.

Cultural materialism is the study of real, objective, materialistic reasons behind human actions in all spheres.



→ Social structure is made up of 3 levels

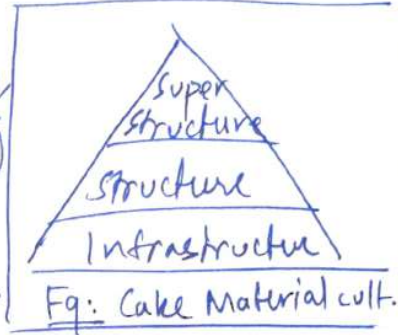
① Infrastructure = Mode of production & mode of reproduction.

② Structure = Organisational level.
(eg) Political, economic system.

③ super-structure = Ideological level
(eg.) religion, taboos etc.

→ As per cultural materialism,
all are functionally interrelated

→ The Infrastructure determines
the structure and super-structure.
structure, super-structure exist to
maximise the Infrastructure.



Case Study → Marvin Harris studied Minhas
Villas in Brazil. Post gold rush, the
Infrastructure changed ~~from~~ farming to
selling of goods and services to gold
miners. This led to change in
structure as economy was integrated
in global money economy. The super-
structure changed with establish-
ment of Urban Ethos

Other important studies

⇒ Patterns of Race in America } Racism was super-structure to ensure more profits at infrastructure level as cheap labor.

⇒ Sacred Cow Complex ⇒ Importance of cow in India as provides milk, ghee, curd, } protein source and oxen for farming.

Significance

- ① Brought a scientific methodology.
- ② Idea of cross-cultural comparisons
- ③ Inspired Chicago School studies in urban Anthro.

Criticisms

- ① Structuralists ⇒ Emic thoughts ignored as individual role
- ② Marxists ⇒ super-structure only for capitalists & vulgar materialism
- ③ ~~Feminists~~ Post modernists against scientific method

④ Rapport: Religion as super-structure affects ~~the~~ infrastructure

While a simplified view, Harris helped in understand^{ing} of racism to the world.